Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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P

Paul (Saul)

Paul was first an enemy who attacked the early Christians, but he later became one of Jesus Christ's most important followers. He became one of the greatest early Christian missionaries and spent his life telling Gentiles (non-Jewish people) about Jesus. Paul influenced Christianity more than anyone else except Jesus. We learn about Paul from two main sources in the New Testament: the book of Acts, where Luke writes about how Paul became a Christian and what he did afterward, and the thirteen letters in the New Testament that are attributed to Paul.

Paul was born in the city of Tarsus to Jewish parents. His parents were Roman citizens, which allowed Paul to become a Roman citizen as well. He grew up in a traditional Jewish home. He worked as a tentmaker (or leatherworker). He studied in Jerusalem under a famous Jewish rabbi named Gamaliel and became a Pharisee. (The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group that carefully followed Jewish laws and oral traditions.) When Paul was a young man, he violently attacked and hurt Christians (Acts 22:3–5).

But then something happened that completely changed his life. The risen Jesus appeared to Paul (Acts 9:3–6; 22:6–10). After this experience, Paul became a follower of Jesus. He spent the rest of his life traveling around the Mediterranean Sea, telling people that Jesus is the Savior and Lord (see Galatians 1:11–16). God specially chose Paul to teach Gentiles about Jesus. Because of Paul's hard work and dedication, many new churches started in different cities during the first century AD. Most of the letters Paul wrote in the New Testament were written to these churches.

Paul believed Jesus was the Jewish Messiah (the special leader God had promised to send to save his people). This made Paul different from other Jews of his time. His vision of Jesus helped him understand that through the death and resurrection of Jesus believers can be made right with God and have their lives changed. Paul no longeBefore, Paul thought people had to carefully follow all of the laws of Moses to please God. But now he understood that being right with God was a gift that came through trusting in Jesus, who died to free people from sin (Romans 4:1–8). He was sure this gift was for everyone, both Jewish people and non-Jewish people.

Paul wrote thirteen letters in the New Testament that discuss many different topics. Some letters explain what Christians believe about salvation and about Jesus Christ (Romans, Galatians, Ephesians, Colossians). Other letters help solve problems in local churches (1 Corinthians). Some teach about how Christians should live together as a community (Ephesians, Colossians). In some letters, Paul explains why he has the authority to teach as an apostle (2 Corinthians, Galatians).

Paul also wrote letters to encourage Christians who were suffering because of their faith (Philippians, 1 Thessalonians). When people were teaching wrong things about Jesus, Paul wrote letters to correct these false teachings (Galatians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians). He wrote some letters to individual people, giving them advice about their life and work for God (1–2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon).

Together, these thirteen letters teach us much about how the first Christians lived and what problems they faced. The letters also show us how Paul understood the Christian faith as being centered on God's gift of grace through Jesus.

Paul's letters focus strongly on Jesus Christ because Paul was completely devoted to him. Paul believed two main things:

1. People can only be saved by trusting in Jesus as their Savior(Galatians 2:16).
2. Believers should give every part of their life to serving Jesus as their Lord (Romans 14:7–9; 2 Corinthians 5:15).

Among New Testament writers, Paul explains salvation most clearly (Romans 1–8). He provides a detailed view of the Christian life and community. His letters also emphasize the Holy Spirit's power in the lives of believers (Romans 8:9–13; Galatians 5:16–25; compare Galatians 2:20; Colossians 1:27). He encourages believers to keep growing to become more like Jesus (Romans 8:30; Ephesians 4:13, 15; 5:1–2).

Believers should live a life of love (1 Corinthians 13:1–13; Ephesians 5:2). They should fully submit to Jesus. More than any other New Testament writer, Paul shows us how and why Christians must base their lives on the gift of grace that comes from Jesus (Romans 12:1–2). For Paul, a believer's entire life (and the whole universe) centers on Jesus alone. Everything finds its true meaning only in relation to Jesus (Colossians 1:15–20; 2:6–3:4).

Luke's account of Paul's missionary life covers about thirty years. It starts with Paul's preaching in Damascus soon after he became a follower of Jesus (around AD 32 to 35). It ends with his imprisonment in Rome in AD 60 to 62. However, the Pastoral Letters (1 Tim-

othy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) seem to be written later. Reliable traditions suggest Paul was released from prison around AD 62 and continued his missionary work. He was later arrested again. Paul had suffered many hardships throughout his life while sharing the good news about Jesus. Finally, he was killed during a time when the Roman emperor Nero was attacking and killing Christians (around AD 64 to 67).

Paul wanted to be like Jesus in every way (even in suffering and death). Paul died knowing that just as Jesus rose from death, he too would one day be raised to new life (Philippians 3:10–11).

Passages for Further Study

Acts 7:58–8:3; 9:1–31; 11:25–30; 12:25–28:31; Romans 1:1–16:27; 1 Corinthians 1:1–16:24; 2 Corinthians 1:1–13:14; Galatians 1:1–6:18; Ephesians 1:1–6:24; Philippians 1:1–4:23; Colossians 1:1–4:18; 1 Thessalonians 1:1–5:28; 2 Thessalonians 1:1–3:18; 1 Timothy 1:1–6:21; 2 Timothy 1:1–4:22; Titus 1:1–3:15; Philemon 1:1–25; 2 Peter 3:15–16

Pharaoh

"Pharaoh" is an Egyptian word that means "great house." It refers to the royal palace and is also a title for the king of Egypt. During Joseph's time, the pharaoh viewed the Israelites favorably. Joseph interpreted the pharaoh's dreams, which led to his promotion as second-in-command in Egypt (Genesis 41:1–44). Pharaoh gave Joseph's family the best land in Egypt (Genesis 45:16–20). The Israelites grew in number and prospered there.

Two pharaohs are mentioned in the book of Exodus, and neither valued the Hebrew people (see Exodus 1:8–10). The first pharaoh ruled when Moses was born. He feared the Hebrews and ordered the killing of all Hebrew baby boys. Moses escaped death and was raised by Pharaoh's daughter in the palace. This pharaoh died after Moses fled from Egypt (Exodus 2:23).

A new pharaoh came to power, and Moses and Aaron later confronted him. This pharaoh was determined to keep the Israelites in Egypt. He stayed stubborn even when he saw God's power. The Bible describes his unwillingness to change (see Exodus 8:32; 9:12, 34–35; compare Romans 1:18–32).

As king, the pharaoh represented the gods' rule over Egypt, giving him complete power. The plagues were God's attacks on Egypt's false gods (see Exodus 12:12). The final plague, the death of the firstborn, targeted Pharaoh's household. This decisive plague convinced Pharaoh to let Israel go. However, after the Israelites left, Pharaoh changed his mind and pursued them to the Red Sea. God's rescue of the defenseless Israelites and the destruction of the powerful Egyptians at the Red Sea is one of the most dramatic rescues in the Old Testament. The Lord revealed himself at the Red Sea as a warrior who fought for his people (Exodus 15:3).

The pharaohs in Exodus are not named, likely following Egyptian tradition. If the Israelites left Egypt in the 1400s BC, the pharaoh might have been Thutmose III, who ruled from around 1504 to 1450 BC. If it occurred in the 1200s BC, based on another timeline, the pharaoh might have been Rameses II, who ruled from around 1279 to 1213 BC.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 1:8–22; 2:14–15, 23; 5:1–15:21

The Pharisees

The Pharisees were one of three major Jewish groups, along with the Sadducees and the Essenes. Unlike some other groups, the Pharisees did not try to gain political power. They began as part of a group called the hasidim (pious ones), who opposed mixing Greek culture and religion with Judaism in the second century BC.

The Pharisees tried to make the Old Testament law practical for Jews who wanted to obey it. They focused on both the written law of Moses (called torah) and oral traditions they said Moses passed down. Their goal was to protect the written law from any violations. They were known for being devout and law-abiding.

The Pharisees shared their interpretations of the law orally from one generation to the next. This created a tradition about legal matters. They made the law relevant by creating specific guidelines for many situations. They believed that if everyone followed the law, the nation would be free of sin, and God would rule over all nations. This future goal motivated their focus on obedience. The Pharisees' traditions later became the rabbinic writings known as the Mishnah and the Talmud.

The Pharisees were a small group. But they had a lot of influence in Israel (see Matthew 15:12–14; see also Josephus, War 2.8.14; Antiquities 13.10.5). They mainly influenced local synagogue communities. The Sadducees, however, were more influential in temple worship in Jerusalem and in the Sanhedrin, the Jewish high council.

Unlike the Sadducees, the Pharisees strongly believed in the resurrection of the dead (see Acts 23:6–8). After Jerusalem's destruction in AD 70, the Pharisees led and guided the people of Israel.

There was often conflict between Jesus and the Pharisees. Jesus accused them of hypocrisy (saying one thing but doing another) and prioritizing human rules over God's righteous standards. He opposed them because they led people away from God's plan for redemption. Although they were Israel's religious leaders, Jesus criticized them as hypocrites for distorting teachings and practices (see Matthew 23). The Pharisees opposed Jesus. They rejected him and his work mainly because he ignored their traditions (see, for example, Matthew 15:1–20).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 3:7; 5:20; 9:10–14, 34; 12:1–14, 22–24, 38–40; 15:1–14; 16:1–12; 19:3; 21:45; 22:15, 34; 23:1–7, 13–31; 27:62–64; Mark 2:23–25; 3:1–6; 7:1–13; 8:11–12; 12:13–17; Luke 5:17–21, 29–32; 6:6–11; 7:28–30, 36–49; 11:37–54; 12:1–3; 13:31; 14:1–6; 15:1–2; 16:13–15; 17:20–21; 18:9–14; 19:38–40; John 1:24–25; 3:1; 7:31–32, 45–52; 8:3–10, 13; 9:13–34, 40; 11:46–57; 12:17–19, 42; 18:3; Acts 5:27–40; 15:5; 23:6–10; 26:4–5; Philippians 3:5–7

Philip

Philip was among the first to share the good news about Jesus with people outside Judea. Highly respected by early Christians, he was one of seven men selected to manage the food distribution program for needy believers in Jerusalem (Acts 6:1–6). Philip was a powerful and effective evangelist (preacher of the good news) through the Spirit's power.

After Stephen's death, Christians fled Jerusalem (Acts 8:1–5). Philip took the message of Christ to Samaria, a city with diverse people. There, he healed many and drove out evil spirits, and people eagerly accepted his message (acts 8:5–8). Many, including a well-known sorcerer named Simon, were baptized (Acts 8:9–13).

An angel then guided Philip to travel southwest from Jerusalem toward Gaza (Acts 8:26). There, the Spirit led him to meet Ethiopia's treasurer, who was returning home from Jerusalem (Acts 8:27–28). The Ethiopian asked Philip to explain Isaiah 53. Philip shared the message about Jesus (Acts 8:30–35) and baptized the man by the roadside (8:36–38). The Spirit of God then suddenly took Philip to Azotus (Acts 8:39–40). He preached the message there and traveled through coastal towns until reaching Caesarea, a large Roman city, where he likely settled (Acts 8:40; 21:8–9).

Many years later, Paul stayed overnight at Philip's home in Caesarea (Acts 21:8). By then, people knew Philip as Philip the Evangelist. He had four unmarried daughters, and all of them had the gift of prophecy (Acts 21:9).

Philip represents early Christian evangelists. The Holy Spirit empowered and guided them to confirm their message (see also Acts 1:8; 3:4–8; 5:12–16; 6:8; 10:9–20; 13:2; 16:6–10; 19:11–12; 20:22–23). Philip followed the Spirit's power and guidance, and God used him to spread the good news beyond Judea.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 6:5; 8:4–13, 26–40; 21:8–9

Philippi

Philippi was a small village in Thrace until around 357 BC. Philip II of Macedon, Alexander the Great's father, conquered and rebuilt it. He named the village after himself, fortified it as a military base, and used the nearby gold mines. Philippi became famous worldwide in 42 BC. It was where Octavian and Mark Antony's imperial armies defeated Brutus and Cassius, Julius Caesar's assassins. This victory paved the way for the Roman Empire under Octavian Augustus.

Many veterans from the war of 42 BC and other battles settled in Philippi. When Paul visited the city, it still showed its Roman military heritage. Located on the Egnatian Way, it was an important stop on the major military road connecting the Adriatic Sea with the Aegean Sea. It had strong civic pride as a Roman colony, enjoying many privileges like tax exemption, and promoted Latin as its official language. Its government was based on the municipal constitution of Rome, and the people considered themselves Romans (see Acts 16:21).

Paul visited the city on his second missionary journey, and the book of Acts describes this visit in detail (Acts 16:12–40). The story often highlights the city's Roman background. Paul uses his Roman citizenship to defend himself successfully (Acts 16:37–39). The city leaders hold the Latin title praetor, translated as stratēgos in Greek (Acts 16:20–22, 38). There seems to have been a small Jewish community there.

The church started with Jewish women who believed and met outside the city because there was no synagogue. Later, they gathered in the home of a well-known woman convert named Lydia (Acts 16:14–15, 40). Luke likely stayed in Philippi when Paul left for Thessalonica (Acts 16:12, 40) and rejoined Paul at Philippi during Paul's third missionary journey several years later (Acts 20:6). Paul wrote a friendly letter to the church at Philippi during one of his imprisonments.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 16:12–40; 20:6; Philippians 1:1; 2:19–30; 4:2–3, 10–22; 1 Thessalonians 2:2

The Philistines

The Philistines lived on the southeast coastal plain of the Mediterranean. They were part of a larger group of sea travelers from the Aegean region, called the "Sea Peoples" by the Egyptians. Around 1200 BC, they settled on the lower coastal plain of Palestine and founded the five cities of:

1. Ashdod
2. Ashkelon
3. Ekron
4. Gaza
5. Gath

The Philistines were not simple; they were skilled in politics and technology. They were also strong warriors. Their iron technology made them nearly unbeatable enemies (see 1 Samuel 13:19–22). They often fought the Israelites during the time of the judges, around 1350 to 1050 BC, and the early united monarchy, from about 1050 to 970 BC. Saul died fighting the Philistines (1 Samuel 31:1–13). However, David defeated them before he became king (1 Samuel 18:20–30; 19:8; 23:1–5) and continued to win against them during his rule (2 Samuel 5:17–25; 8:1; 21:15–22). Although the Philistines never fully disappeared while Israel existed as a nation (2 Kings 18:8; 2 Chronicles 17:11; 21:16–17; 26:6–7; 28:18), David effectively ended their threat.

In 1 Samuel, God used the Philistines to remove Eli's sinful family (1 Samuel 4:10–22). The Philistines also helped build David's military and political career (1 Samuel 17:32–58; 18:20–30). They distracted Saul when he was close to capturing David (1 Samuel 23:26–28). They gave David refuge from Saul (1 Samuel 21:10–15; 27:1–12). They stopped David from fighting his own people (1 Samuel 29:1–11). They killed Saul and his sons (1 Samuel 31:1–13). This made it possible for David to become king. However, in the end, the Philistines experienced God's judgment (see Ezekiel 25:15–17; Amos 1:6–8).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 10:13–14; Judges 3:1–3; Judges 13:1–16:31; 1 Samuel 5:1–6:18; 13:16–14:23; 21:10–15; 23:1–5, 26–28; 31:1–10; 2 Samuel 5:17–25; 8:1; 21:15–22; 2 Kings 18:8; 2 Chronicles 17:10–11; 21:16–17; 26:6–7; 28:18–19; Isaiah 2:6; Ezekiel 25:15–17; Amos 1:6–8; 9:7

Pontius Pilate

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26 to 36. He ordered Jesus to be put to death on a cross around AD 30 or 33.

As the governor of Judea, Pilate controlled the Roman forces and the temple, including its funds. He alone could order criminals to be punished with death (see John 18:31). Therefore, the Jewish authorities had to present charges to Pilate to have Jesus killed (Mark 15:1–4).

Pilate often acted harshly as governor. He took temple funds to build a 56-kilometer (35-mile) aqueduct for Jerusalem. This led to a major protest from the people. In response, Pilate sent soldiers in disguise to the crowds. They beat the protesters to death with clubs (Josephus, War 2.9.4; Antiquities 18.3.2).

On another occasion, Pilate killed some Galileans while they were offering sacrifices at the temple (Luke 13:1). This incident might have caused tension with the Galilean ruler Herod Antipas. Pilate also attempted to bring images of Caesar into Jerusalem for worship. Later, in AD 36, Pilate killed pilgrims who followed a Samaritan false prophet. This event led to his removal by Emperor Tiberius in the same year.

Each Gospel describes Pilate's role in the death of Jesus (Matthew 27:11–26; Mark 15:1:1–15; Luke 23:1–25; John 18:28–19:16; see also Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28; 1 Timothy 6:13). After questioning Jesus, Pilate believed Jesus did not deserve death. He tried to return the case to the Jewish authorities. When they refused, he attempted to send Jesus to Herod Antipas, who also declined. Pilate then tried to use a Roman tradition of releasing a prisoner during Passover.

Meanwhile, his wife was troubled by a dream about "that innocent man" (Matthew 27:19). However, the crowd became threatening, and Jewish leaders suggested Pilate was not taking the threat Jesus posed to Rome seriously. Pilate gave in to their pressure. He ordered Jesus to be whipped and crucified, with the title "King of the Jews" on a sign above him. Pilate did this only after strongly objecting and declaring himself innocent of this unjust death (Matthew 27:18–25; Mark 15:14; Luke 23:4, 13–23; John 18:38; 19:4–16). Pilate's attitude shows that Jesus was not a threat to Rome, only to the Jewish leaders. This might have been important for later Christians, who were seen as a threat to Rome.

After Jesus died, Pilate allowed Joseph of Arimathea to take the body of Jesus from the cross and bury it (Matthew 27:57–61; Mark 15:42–46; Luke 23:50–53; John 19:38–42). Pilate also let the Jewish leaders seal the tomb to prevent anyone from stealing the body or making false claims about Jesus rising from the dead (Matthew 27:62–66).

Priscilla and Aquila

We do not know much about what happened to Pilate after he was removed as governor in AD 36. A church historian named Eusebius wrote that Pilate killed himself during the time when Caligula was the Roman emperor, from AD 37 to 41 (Eusebius, Church History 2.7).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 27:2, 11–26, 57–58, 62–65; Mark 15:1–15, 43–45; Luke 3:1; 13:1; 23:1–25, 52; 18:28–19:16; 19:31, 38; Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28; 1 Timothy 6:13

Priscilla and Aquila

Priscilla and Aquila were a Christian couple. Paul lived and worked with them in his early days in Corinth. Later, they were active in Christian ministry and helped Apollos truly understand Jesus. They often welcomed other Christians into their home.

Paul first met Priscilla and Aquila in Corinth. They had recently arrived because the Roman emperor Claudius Caesar had deported all Jews from Rome in AD 49. Paul got to know them, and since they were tentmakers (or possibly leatherworkers) like him, he lived and worked with them during his first year and a half in Corinth, from AD 50 to 52 (Acts 18:1–3).

When Paul left Corinth, he took Priscilla and Aquila with him and left them in Ephesus (Acts 18:18–19). He returned to Jerusalem and Antioch. Later, when Apollos came to Ephesus, he preached enthusiastically about Jesus in the synagogues. Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and explained the truth of Jesus more fully. With their help, Apollos became a powerful teacher who shared the good news about Jesus and defended the Christian faith (Acts 18:24–28).

Later, Paul mentions their home as a meeting place for Christians in Ephesus. He includes their greeting with his own to the church in Corinth (1 Corinthians 16:19; see also 2 Timothy 4:19). It seems they later returned to Rome, likely after Claudius's edict was relaxed. Paul sends his greetings to them first when he writes to the church in Rome (Romans 16:3–5). Their home there also became a meeting place. Paul clearly felt a strong friendship with them and valued their work for Jesus. He calls them "my fellow workers in Christ Jesus" and mentions they risked their lives for him.

Priscilla and Aquila were early Christians who boldly shared their faith in their daily work. They actively served others as a married couple dedicated to Jesus. Priscilla's name often appears first, which was unusual then. This might indicate her strong role in their ministry and witness.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 18:1–3, 18–19, 24–28; Romans 16:3–5; 1 Corinthians 16:19; 2 Timothy 4:19